

pieces in the classical repertoire. However, these four violin concertos represent only a tiny part of his output. In addition to about 500 concertos (almost half of them for his own instrument, the violin), he wrote 50 or so operas, of which 16 survive complete and others in part, a large amount of sacred music, numerous sonatas for one or two instruments, and various other compositions. Critics have accused him of overproduction and repetition, but his finest creations rank among the greatest of their time.

Vivaldi was born in Venice and although he traveled a good deal, within Italy and elsewhere, he spent most of his life in the city. His father, who started out as a barber, was such a good amateur violinist that he was able to turn professional, and in 1685 he began working as a musician at St. Mark's Church.



VENICE, FRANCESCO GUARDI

This 18th-century painting of Venice is a contemporary view of the city so closely associated with Vivaldi. He was born, ordained, and fêted there for much of his life, leaving just a year before his death.